CLASSIFIED DOSSIER

THE MIDNIGHT VISITOR

Robert Arthur

CONTEXT:

Class 10 English | Footprints Without Feet | Chapter 3

MISSION BRIEF:

A gloomy French hotel. A top-secret report. A deadly intruder. And a sloppy secret agent whose greatest weapon is his mind.

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THE SPY ILLUSION: EXPECTATION VS. REALITY

TOP SECRET

Fowler's Romantic Vision

DOSS: ROMANTICIZED CONCEPT

DRAMATIC FLIGHT OF FANCY

- Mysterious figures in the night
- The crack of pistols
- Drugs in the wine & dark-eyed beauties
- Dealing in espionage and danger

NO BASIS IN FACT

The Prosaic Reality

DOSS: ACTUAL OPERATIONAL ENVIRONMENT

- Dull evening in a French music hall
- A sloppy, fat man

ROUTINE SURVEILLANCE

- Prosaic telephone calls making appointments
- Fowler feels completely let down and bored

CONFIRMED BOREDOM

INTELLIGENCE ASSESSMENT: HIGH DISCREPANCY CONFIRMED

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TARGET PROFILE: AUSABLE

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The Hidden Truth:
He may look ordinary, but beneath the wheezing voice lies a razor-sharp intellect and masterful presence of mind.

Appearance: Fat. Very fat. Sloppy. Sloppy. Scarcely a romantic figure.

Voice/Origin: Speaks French and German passably, but retained a heavy American accent (brought from Boston to Paris 20 years ago).

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TOP SECRET

THE AUTHENTIC THRILL: MAX

The Intruder:
Slender, a little less than tall.

NCERT Keyword:
Features suggesting the crafty, pointed countenance of a fox.

The Threat:
Armed with a pistol. Aside from the gun, nothing especially menacing.

The Reaction:
Ausable simply blinks and wheezes, "Max, you gave me quite a start. I thought you were in Berlin."

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THE OBJECTIVE: A PAPER THAT COULD CHANGE HISTORY

The Stakes:
A highly classified report concerning new missiles.

[redacted]

The Risk:
Several men and women have already risked their lives for it.

The Demand:
Max demands the report, claiming, “It will be safer in my hands than in yours.”

[redacted]

The Tension:
The paper is set to arrive at I2:30. Drama and danger have officially entered the room.

[redacted]

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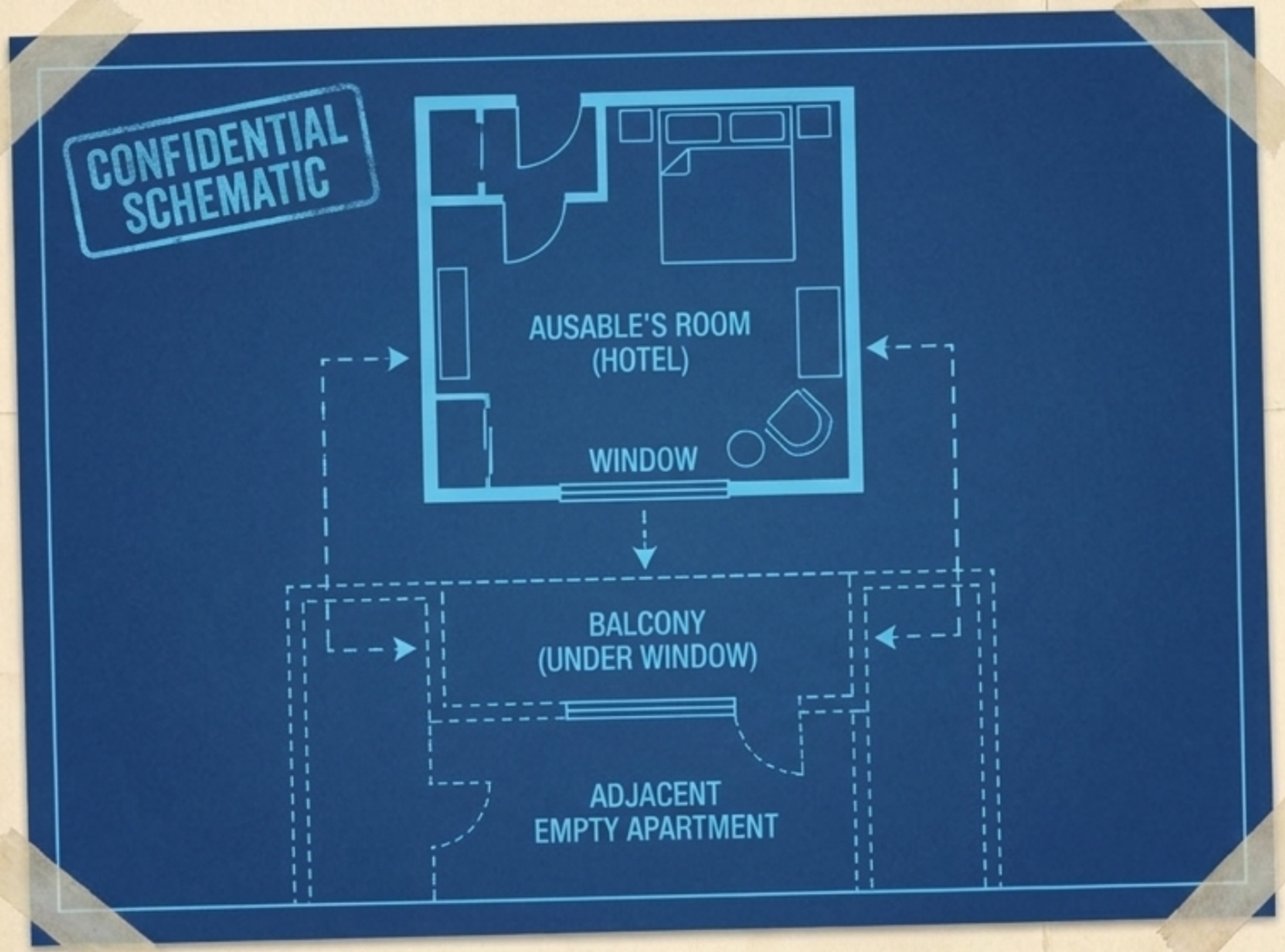
TOP SECRET

PSYCHOLOGICAL WARFARE: THE FAKE BALCONY



THE SETUP:
Ausable complains grimly to management about a nuisance balcony.

THE LIE:
He claims his room used to be part of a larger unit. A balcony from the next empty apartment extends directly under his window.

THE BAIT:
Max admits he used a passkey, stating he didn't know about the balcony-it would have saved him trouble.

WHY IT WORKS: Ausable's extreme, believable irritation sells the geographical lie completely.

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THE WAITING GAME

THE CONTRAST: Ausable remains entirely calm in his armchair, planting the seeds of his trap.

MAX smiles evilly, nervous but trying to stay in control.

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THE TIME: “Thirty-one minutes,” Ausable says moodily. The appointment is for 12:30.
THE ATMOSPHERE: Heavy suspense. The night presses blackly against the ordinary window.

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THE CATALYST: A SUDDEN KNOCK

TOP SECRET

TOP SECRET

A voice calls out:
“Mr. Ausable! Mr. Ausable!”

Fowler’s Reaction:
Jumps in shock at the sudden sound.

Max’s Reaction:
Bites his lip nervously, his face turning black with with anger.

Ausable’s Reaction:
Just smiles calmly. The trap is springing shut.

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AUSABLE'S MASTERSTROKE: THE POLICE TRAP

STEP 1: THE REASON

Such an important paper needs a little extra protection.

STEP 2: THE REQUEST

I told them to check on me to make sure everything was all right.

STEP 3: THE ULTIMATUM

If I do not answer... they will enter anyway. The door is unlocked.

STEP 4: THE THREAT

They will not hesitate to shoot.

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PANIC AND THE PLUNGE

The Retreat: Max backs to the window, twisting his body to cover the men.

The Demand: “Send them away or I’ll shoot and take my chances!”

The Climax: Max drops to the fake balcony, screaming once, shrilly.

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THE DOOR OPENS...

THE REVEAL:
There are no police.
Only Henry, the waiter.

THE DELIVERY:
“Here is the drink you ordered for when you returned.” He deftly uncorks the bottle and leaves.

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THE SHOCK: Fowler is left white-faced, staring and stammering in complete disbelief: “But... the police...”

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The Ultimate Weapon

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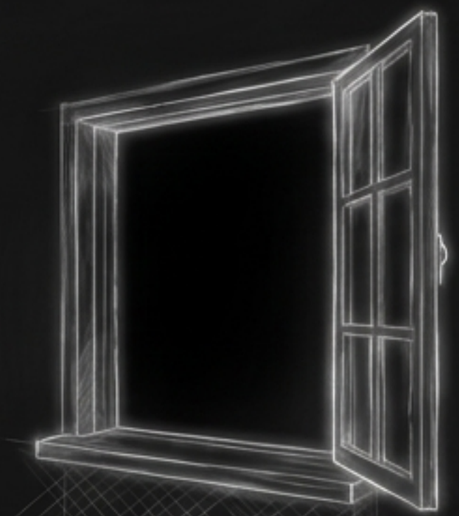
Fowler: “But won’t that man out on the balcony...?”

Ausable (sighing): “No, he won’t return.”

The Twist: You see, my young friend, there is NO balcony.



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The Insight: Ausable defeated an armed, dangerous spy without ever raising a finger—using only a fabricated story and brilliant timing.

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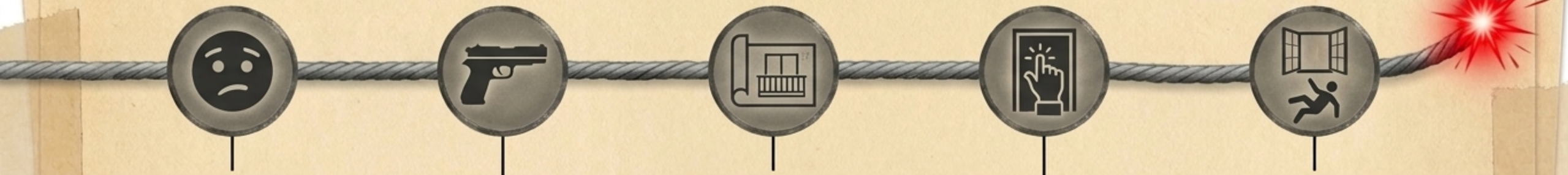
Plot Timeline Mastery



Beat I: The Disappointment
-> Fowler expects a thrilling spy; meets fat, ordinary Ausable.

Beat 2: The Ambush
-> Max waits in the room with a pistol, demanding the missile report.

Beat 3: The Fabrication
-> Ausable brilliantly invents the detailed story of a nuisance balcony.

Beat 4: The Knock
-> A waiter arrives, but Ausable calmly claims it’s the armed police.

Beat 5: The Fall
-> Max panics, jumps out the window onto the non-existent balcony, and falls.

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Key Lexicon: Board Exam Keywords

Romantic

Imaginative; having a fantastic view of reality.

Prosaic

Ordinary, dull, lacking imagination.

Espionage

The practice of spying.

Sloppy

Carelessly dressed; untidy.

Passably

Just well enough; tolerably well.

Shrilly

Piercingly; in a high, sharp pitch (describing Max's final scream).

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Exam Ready: Themes, Traits & Core Insights

TOP SECRET

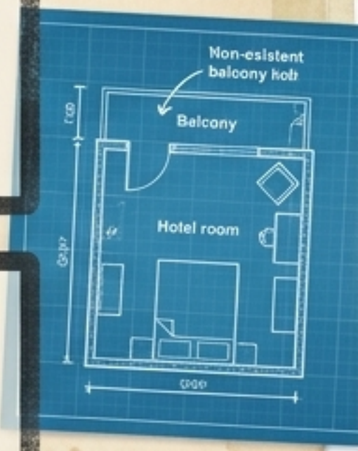
Core Theme: Appearance vs. Reality

Ausable shatters the stereotype of the glamorous James Bond spy. He proves that physical fitness is secondary to mental sharpness. Looks are deeply deceptive.

TOP SECRET

Ausable's Character

Highly observant, quick-witted, sluggish in appearance but razor-sharp in thought. He never panics.



The Core Concept: Presence of Mind

The ability to think quickly, act calmly, and invent flawless solutions instantly in a situation of extreme, unexpected danger.

Key Exam Answer Phrase

Ausable capitalized on events as they happened. He used the waiter's routine knock to validate his fake police story, driving Max into a fatal panic without ever touching a weapon.

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